US EQUITY VIEWS

The rise and reach of retail trading in US equities

- **Retail trading activity has inflected higher alongside the recent equity market rally.** GS trading desk estimates show that retail trading volumes have risen by 28% since mid-April and a basket of retail favorite stocks (GSXURFAV) has rallied by 29% over the same period. The recent replacement of pattern day trader rules with less stringent margin requirements increases the likelihood that retail trading activity will rise further.
- **We estimate retail traders hold $12 trillion of equity assets in self-directed brokerage accounts, amounting to approximately 10% of total US corporate equity market value.** Retail traders are a subset of US households, which directly and indirectly own the majority of the $111 trillion US corporate equity market.
- **Retail trading activity has recently accounted for roughly 20% of total US equity trading volumes.** This is up from 15% a decade ago but below the peak of 24% in 2021. Specialized market makers known as wholesalers execute the majority of retail order flow. As a result, institutional investors typically interact with only a fraction of retail trading activity.
- **Retail trading activity has increased during recent equity market drawdowns.** Retail volumes in index-linked ETFs rose during the equity market selloffs in 2020, 2022, and 2025. During the most recent selloff, volumes remained light but increased as the market rebounded. In addition to market-wide selloffs, retail trading activity has tended to increase in individual stocks with sharp declines.
- **Retail investors employ both margin and leveraged ETFs to boost their equity market exposures.** Retail margin debt across select brokers currently equates to 1.8% of customer assets, similar to the previous high reached in 2021. The retail share of trading volumes in leveraged S&P 500 and Nasdaq-100 ETFs has been roughly double the share in unleveraged ETFs tracking the same indices.
- **Retail trading activity has recently tilted towards stocks with small market caps, volatile returns, and high valuations.** Retail also tends to trade more actively in stocks with high short interest. The retail share of trading volumes in Russell 3000 stocks with the highest short interest was higher in 2025 than in 2021.
- **Stocks with elevated retail trading activity generally carry elevated**

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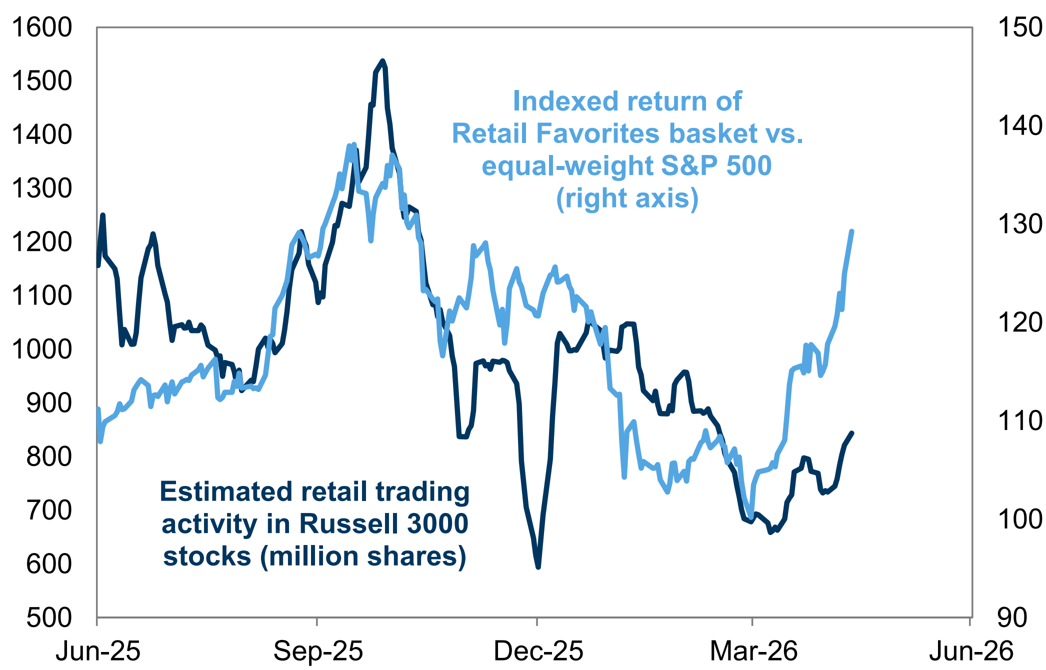
valuations and exhibit above-average volatility, even controlling for fundamentals like sales growth. Stocks with elevated retail trading activity have also exhibited greater underperformance following earnings misses, suggesting that elevated retail participation may affect how stock prices move to reflect fundamental information.

Retail traders in the equity ownership landscape

Following a decline in early 2026, retail trading activity has inflected higher alongside the recent equity market rally. GS Global Banking & Markets estimates of retail trading volumes show a 28% increase in retail trading activity since mid-April. Mirroring this increase, a basket of stocks popular with retail traders (GSXURFAV) has rallied by 29% over the same period. See Exhibit 25 for the current constituents of GSXURFAV with the largest recent retail share of trading volumes. The recent replacement of pattern day trader rules with less stringent margin requirements increases the likelihood that retail trading activity will rise further.

Exhibit 1: Retail favorite stocks have rallied alongside a rebound in retail trading activity

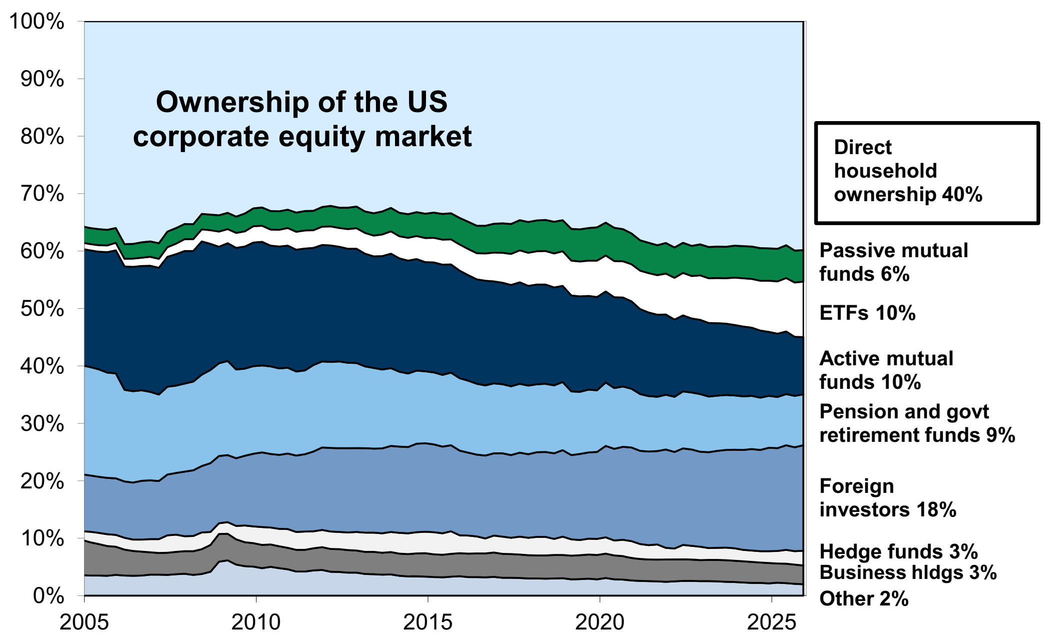


GSXURFAV basket developed by GS Global Banking & Markets. Retail trading activity reflects GS Global Banking & Markets' estimates of total shares executed on behalf of retail investors.

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Goldman Sachs FICC and Equities

Retail traders are a subset of US households, which are the largest owner of the US equity market. We define retail investors as individuals making self-directed trading decisions in brokerage accounts. The Fed's latest Financial Accounts of the United States data (Z.1) show that US households are the largest owner of corporate equities. Of the $111 trillion value of corporate equity assets, 40% is directly held by households. Including indirect ownership via retirement accounts, mutual funds, and ETFs, households own the majority of the US corporate equity market.

Exhibit 2: Ownership of the US equity market

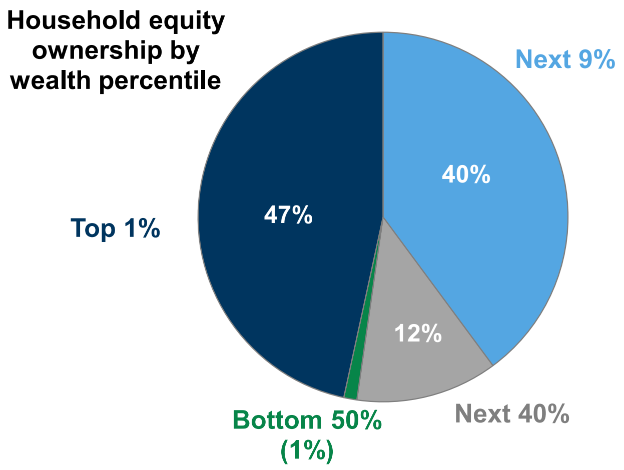


Source: Federal Reserve, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Household equity ownership is concentrated at the top of the wealth distribution. The top 10% of households own 87% of total household equity assets while the bottom 50% of households own just 1% of the total.

However, households in the bottom half of the wealth distribution have historically made larger adjustments to their equity portfolios from quarter to quarter. Across the average quarter since 1990, flows into and out of equities from the bottom 50% of households amounted to 3% of their assets, nearly three times the average for the top 10% of households.

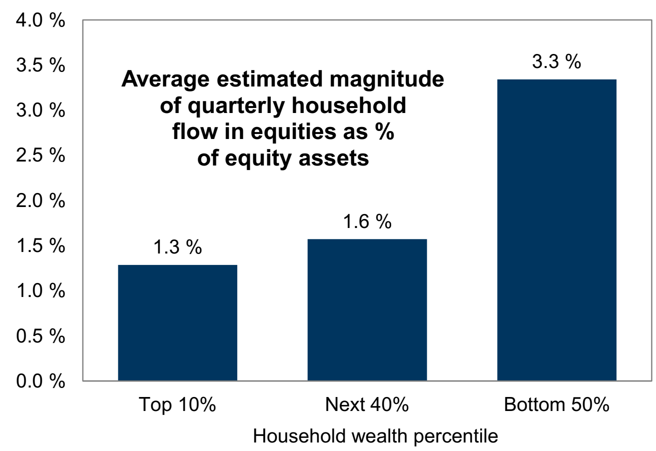
Exhibit 3: Equity ownership share by wealth percentile



The "Household" sector described in the DFAs includes private funds such as hedge funds. We reduce the value of the "Top 1%" category's assets by the Federal Reserve's estimate of hedge fund corporate equity assets.

Source: Federal Reserve, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

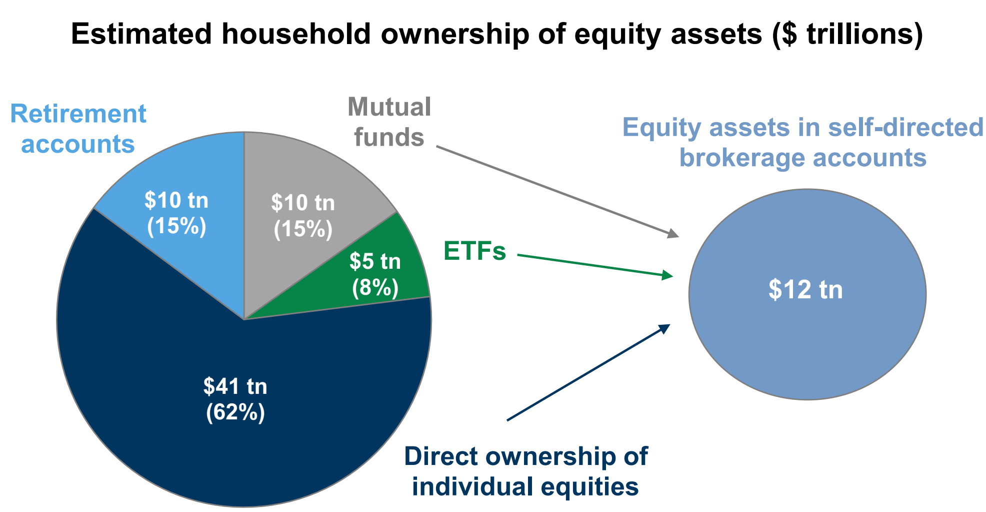
Exhibit 4: Variation in household equity flows by wealth percentile
quarterly since 1990



Source: Federal Reserve, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

We estimate that equity assets in self-directed brokerage accounts total $12 trillion, or 18% of US household directly- and indirectly-owned equity assets. This equates to approximately 10% of total US corporate equity market value. The remaining share represents household equity assets held outside self-directed brokerage accounts, including the value of equity assets held in retirement accounts and equity ownership stakes in private companies, for example.

Exhibit 5: We estimate 18% of households' equity assets are held in self-directed brokerage accounts

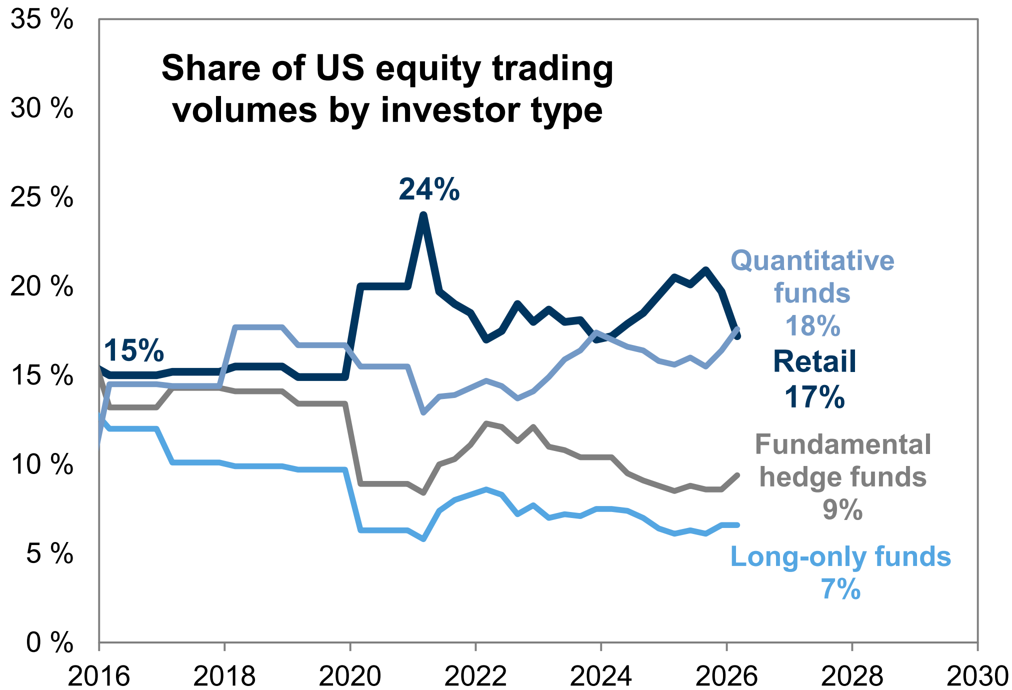


Includes ownership of foreign equities. Estimated equity assets in self-directed brokerage account reflects both direct equity ownership and ownership of equities through mutual fund and ETF shares. See appendix for estimation methodology.

Source: Federal Reserve, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Although retail trading assets represent roughly 10% of US corporate equity assets, retail trading activity has recently accounted for roughly 20% of total US equity trading volumes. According to Bloomberg estimates, retail traders accounted for 19% of US equity trading volumes on average over the last 4 quarters, below a peak of 24% in 2021 and up from 15% a decade ago. As of Q1 2026 retail traders accounted for 17% of US equity trading volumes. Nevertheless, retail's 17% share of trading volume is smaller than the 34% attributable to institutional investors in aggregate. FINRA estimates show that retail accounts for a smaller 11% of trading volumes.

Exhibit 6: Retail share of trading activity has risen in past decade
Latest estimate as of Q1 2026



Remaining share of trading activity is attributable to banks and market makers.

Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

However, institutional investors typically interact directly with only a small portion of retail order flow. Retail brokers route over 87% of order flow to specialized market makers known as wholesalers. A recent analysis from Schwarz et al. (2025) suggests that wholesalers execute 84% of retail orders against their own inventories, a practice known as internalization. Retail orders that are not internalized are routed to another market maker, to dark pools, or to traditional exchanges. As a result, investors are able to access directly only a small share of retail trading activity.

Retail trading volumes are more likely to reach exchanges in volatile markets or when retail order flow becomes large and correlated, however. A 2021 SEC report noted that an increase in on-exchange volumes during volatility spikes may partly reflect wholesalers seeking to avoid internalizing retail orders as hedging becomes more difficult. Furthermore, large and imbalanced retail order flow makes it challenging for wholesalers to keep bid-ask spreads tighter than on-exchange spreads.

Retail trader assets are currently concentrated among a handful of large brokers.

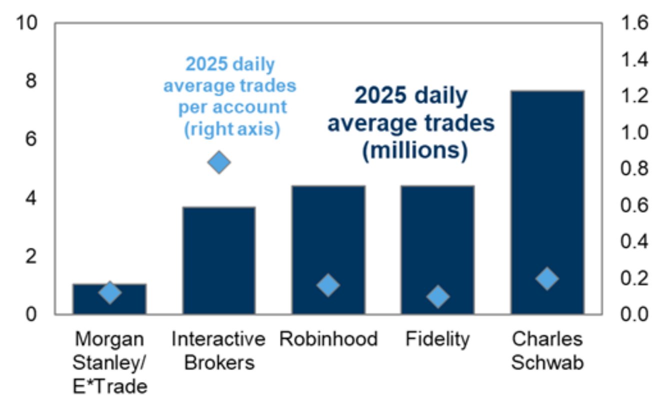
Retail self-directed assets at Charles Schwab, Fidelity, and Vanguard account for roughly 80% of total retail self-directed assets, while Robinhood accounts for just 2%. In 2025, aggregated daily average trades were highest at Charles Schwab, totaling 8 million daily average trades. Daily average trades per account were highest at Interactive Brokers, whose accounts exhibited roughly 4 times the activity of remaining brokers with available data.

Exhibit 7: Retail investor assets are spread across multiple brokers

Broker	Retail self-directed assets (trillions)	Share of retail self-directed assets
Charles Schwab	$6.6	38 %
Fidelity	4.4	25
Vanguard	2.8	16
Morgan Stanley / E*Trade	1.6	9
Wirehouses ex MS	0.9	5
Interactive Brokers	0.3	2
Robinhood	0.3	2
Other	0.5	3
Total	**$17.5**	**100 %**

Source: Cerulli Associates, Company data, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 8: Trading activity across select retail brokers



Number of 2025 retail accounts at Fidelity is estimated based on number of retail accounts in 2024, 2025 growth in total customer accounts, and proportion of retail accounts to total customer accounts from 2021-2024.

Source: Data compiled by Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Characteristics of retail trading activity

To analyze retail trading activity we utilize stock-level estimates of retail trading volumes from GS Global Banking & Markets. These estimates largely rely on identifying retail trades in Trade Reporting Facility (TRF) data using an identification method from Boehmer et al. (2021). This approach has become common in academic literature studying retail trading activity[1]. Academic research has also shown that estimates of retail trading activity using this methodology are likely conservative, particularly for stocks that trade with wide bid-ask spreads[2].

Margin debt and leverage

Margin debt has recently surged to new highs. Margin debt across all FINRA member firms rose to $1.3 trillion this year, or 52% of gross customer balances. This share is the highest level on record and 6 pp above the previous highest reading in 1998.

[1] Several papers that utilize this identification strategy when analyzing retail volumes include Barber, Lin, and Odean (2023), Farrell et al. (2022), and Liu, Zhang, and Zhang (2026).

[2] See Barber et al. (2024).

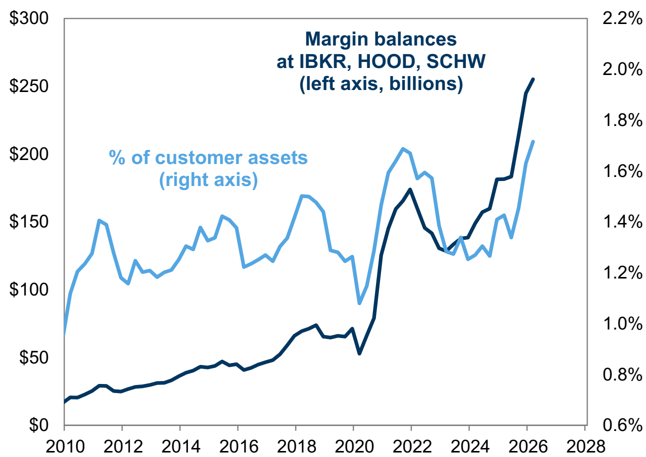
Exhibit 9: Margin debt remains near record highs

Source: FINRA, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Margin balances have also increased sharply at several retail brokers. Margin balances at Interactive Brokers, Robinhood, and Charles Schwab registered $230 billion at the end of March, equating to 1.8% of customer assets. This share is now slightly above the previous record from 2021 but has not meaningfully surpassed that high, in contrast with FINRA data.

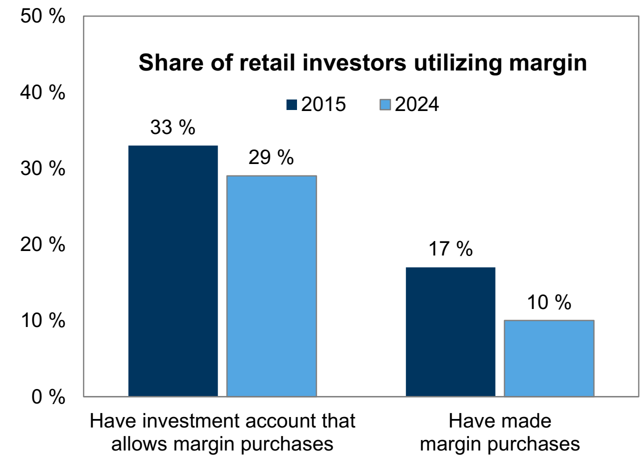
Much of the rise in total margin debt over the past decade has likely been driven by institutional investors. FINRA's margin statistics show a $737 billion increase in margin debt over the past decade vs. a $189 billion increase in margin balances at Interactive Brokers, Robinhood, and Charles Schwab in aggregate. Furthermore, a recent FINRA survey shows that the proportion of retail investors who own margin accounts and who make margin purchases has declined since 2015.

Exhibit 10: Margin balances at several retail brokers have surged



Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

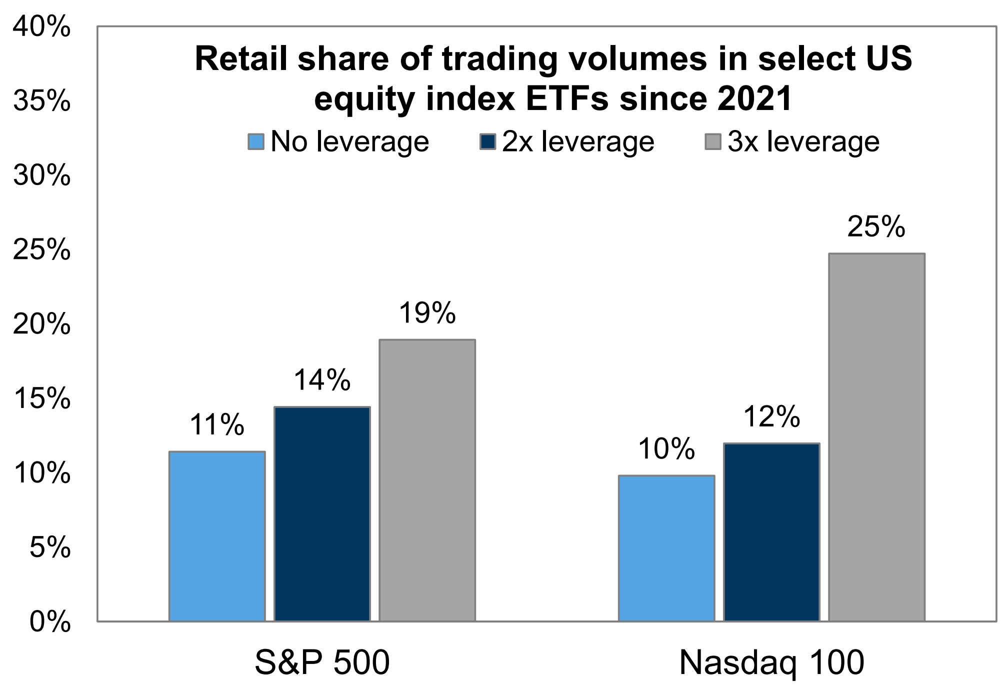
Exhibit 11: FINRA survey of retail investors suggests margin usage has become less prevalent



Source: FINRA, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

In addition to margin, retail traders amplify returns via leveraged ETFs. Since 2021, the retail share of trading volumes in leveraged index ETFs has been roughly double the share in ETFs tracking the same indices without leverage.

Exhibit 12: Retail trading activity has been higher in leveraged US equity index ETFs

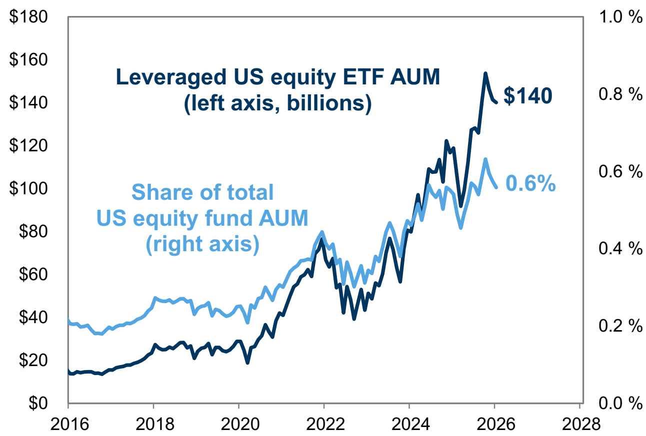


ETFs included in analysis are the largest ETFs by AUM tracking the S&P 500 or Nasdaq 100 in their respective leverage category. VOO, SSO, SPXL, QQQ, QLD, TQQQ.

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

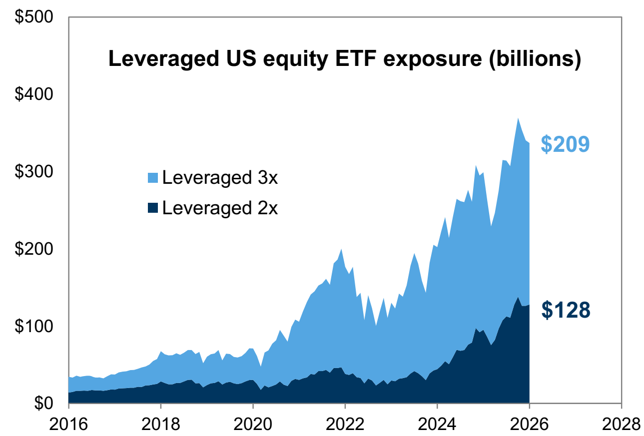
Leveraged ETF AUM has grown from $16 billion to $140 billion over the past decade. Today, leveraged ETF AUM accounts for market exposure of roughly $370 billion. Despite the growth in assets, these funds still represent less than 1% of total US equity mutual fund and ETF AUM.

Exhibit 13: Leveraged US equity ETF AUM has grown by more than $100 billion during the past decade



Source: EPFR, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 14: Market exposure of leveraged US equity ETF assets

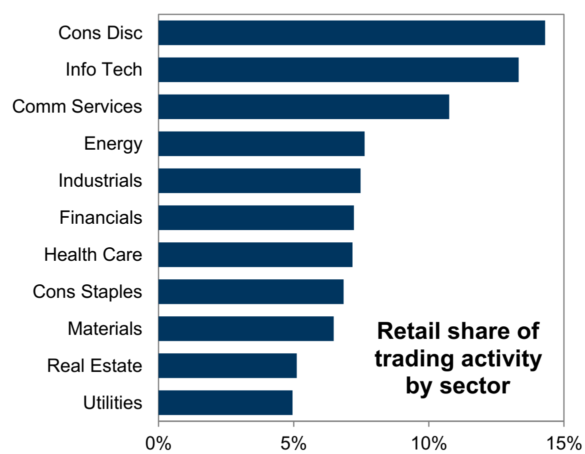


Source: EPFR, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Sectors, factor, and size tilts

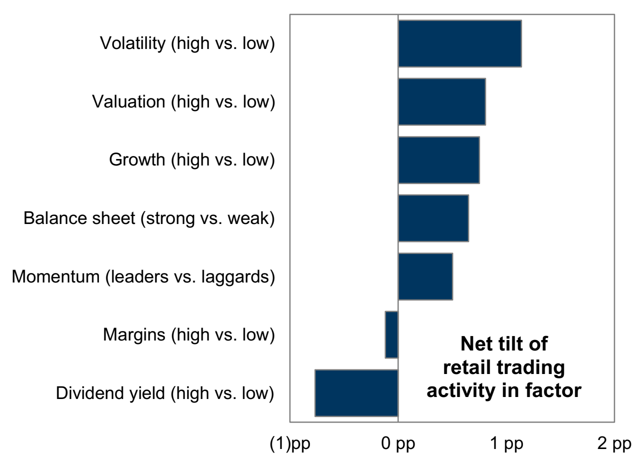
Across sectors, retail trading volumes have been the highest share of trading volumes within Consumer Discretionary and Technology. Within sectors, retail trading activity this year has tilted toward more volatile stocks and stocks with higher valuations.

Exhibit 15: Retail trading activity is more prevalent in the Consumer Discretionary and Info Tech sectors
Market cap weighted average based on data across Russell 3000 stocks since 2021



Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 16: Retail trading activity is tilted towards more volatile and higher valuation stocks
Average in long leg minus average in short leg. Based on retail activity data across S&P 500 stocks YTD

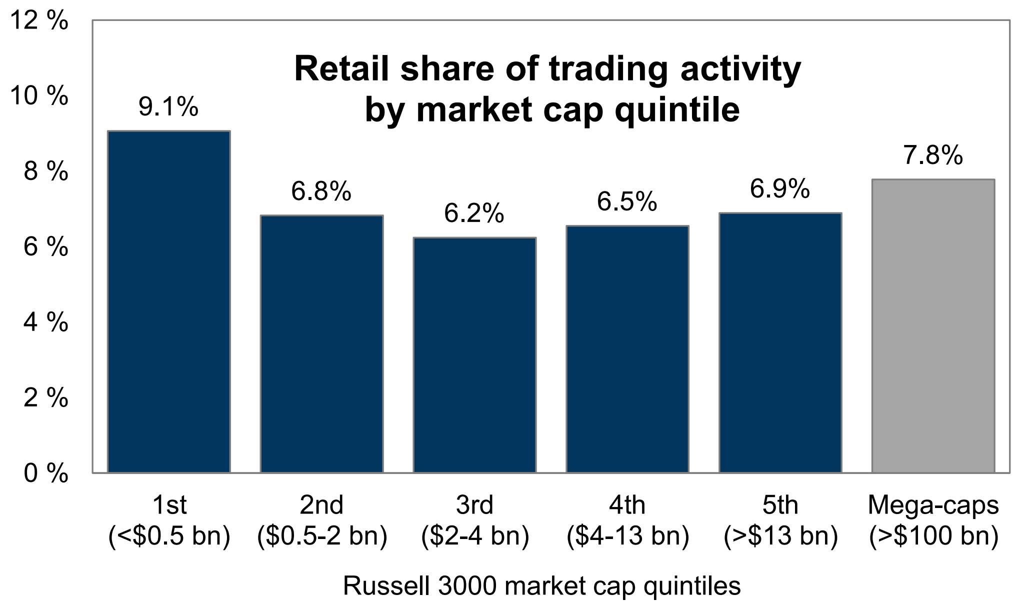


Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Retail trading activity is highest in stocks with the smallest market caps. Year to date, retail has accounted for 9% of trading volumes on average across stocks in the bottom quintile of Russell 3000 market cap, which includes companies with market caps ranging from $16 million to $500 million. Among stocks with market-caps greater than $1 billion, however, retail trading activity is tilted slightly towards mega-caps. Retail has accounted for 8% of trading volumes on average in stocks with market caps greater than

$100 billion year to date.

Exhibit 17: Retail's share of trading activity varies by market cap
Based on retail activity data across Russell 3000 stocks YTD

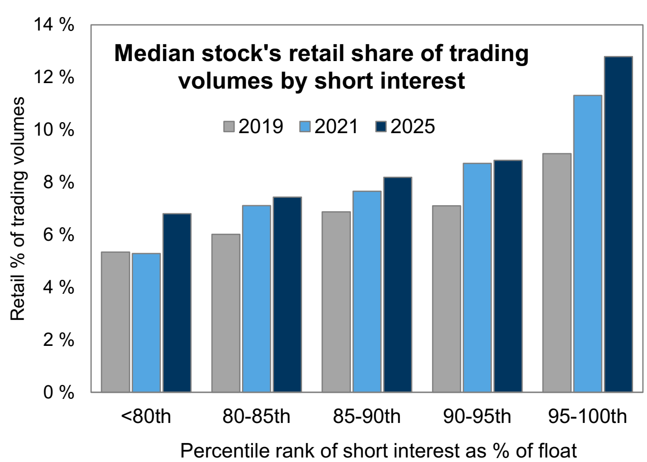


Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Short interest

Retail traders are generally more active in stocks with high levels of short interest. In 2025, retail trading activity accounted for 13% of volumes for the top 5% of stocks based on short interest. This marks an increase from 9% in 2019 and 11% in 2021.

Exhibit 18: Retail trading activity is more pronounced in stocks with high short interest
Russell 3000 stocks



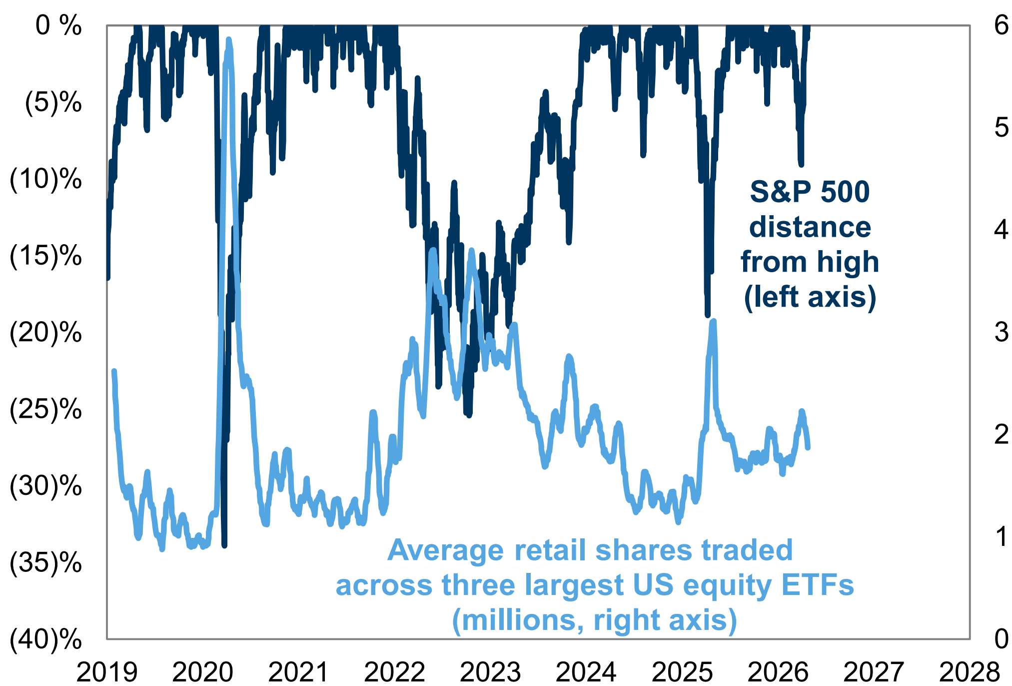
Short interest based on average short interest across year.

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Equity market drawdowns

Retail trading activity in index-linked US equity ETFs has increased during each of the largest recent equity market selloffs. Retail trading volumes in the largest US equity ETFs (SPY, VOO, IVV) increased markedly during S&P 500 drawdowns in 2020, 2022, and 2025. While trading volumes across all investor types tend to rise during drawdowns, the retail share of trading in these ETFs also increased in 2020 and 2022. In contrast, during the 2025 selloff, retail trading volumes in the largest index ETFs increased sharply in absolute terms but declined as a share of total trading volumes. During the S&P 500 drawdown in March 2026, retail trading volumes in index ETFs rose only modestly in absolute terms and again declined as a share of total trading volumes.

Exhibit 19: Retail trading activity in index products rises around selloffs
Retail shares traded series reflects 21-day moving average

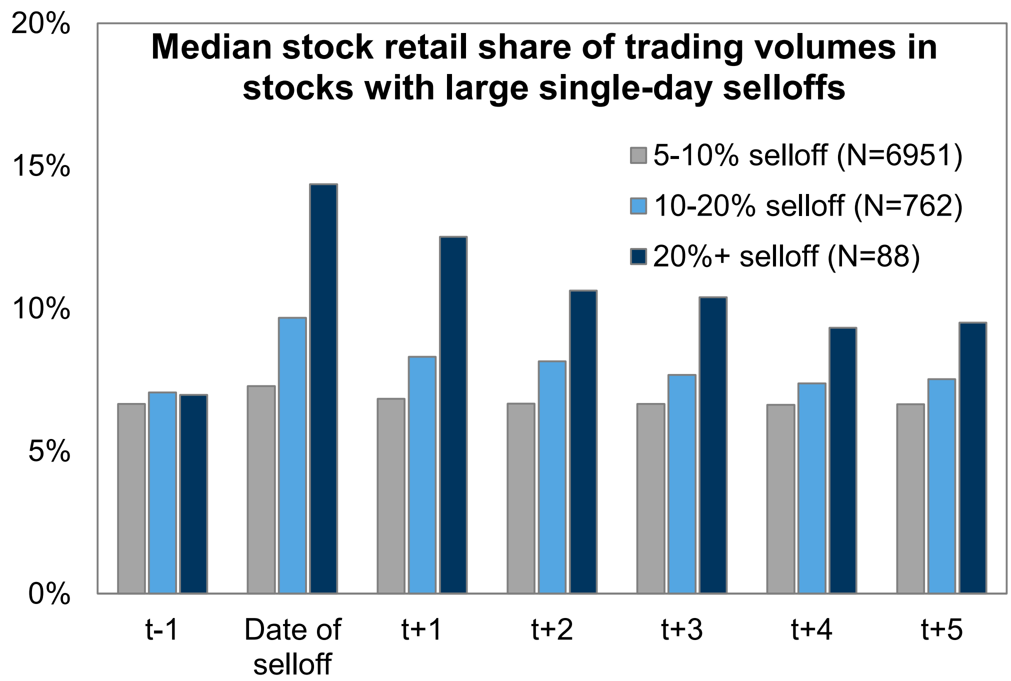


ETFs include VOO, IVV, SPY

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Within the market, retail trading activity has also tended to increase in stocks with sharp single-day declines. Stocks with larger declines have generally experienced larger increases in retail activity, and the elevated activity has generally persisted during the few days subsequent to the selloff.

Exhibit 20: Share of retail trading activity also rises following stock selloffs, particularly following larger selloffs
Based on sample of 1-day selloffs of at least 5% across S&P 500 stocks since 2021

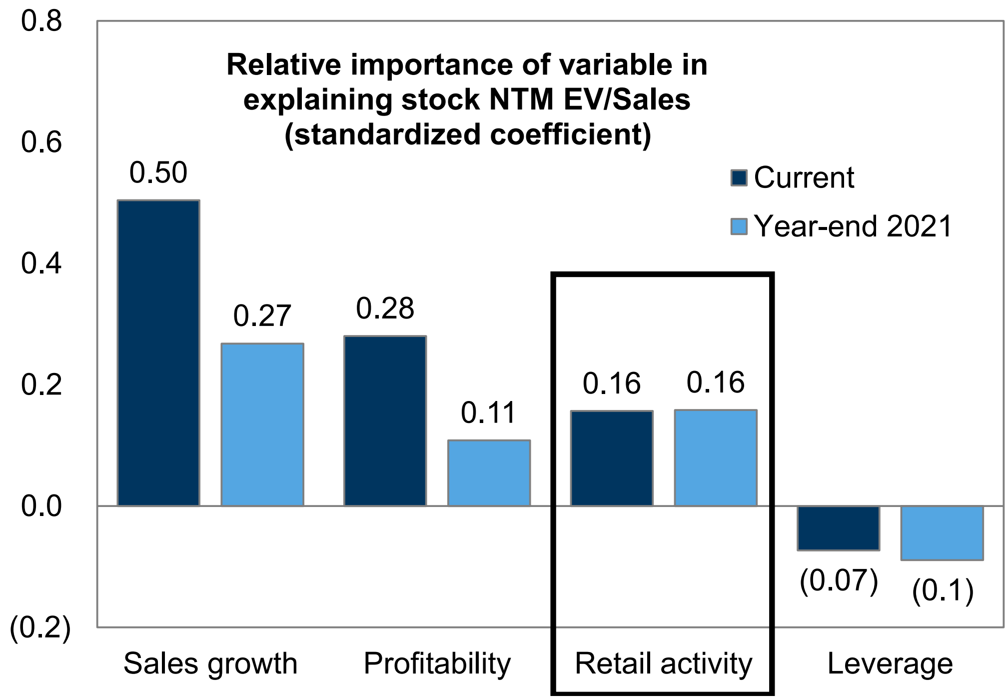


Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

How retail trading interacts with markets

Stocks with above-average retail trading activity generally have above-average valuations, controlling for fundamental factors. A cross-sectional regression of EV/sales multiples across Russell 3000 stocks indicates that fundamental variables such as sales growth and profitability are the primary drivers of stock valuations today. Nevertheless, even after controlling for these characteristics, a one standard deviation increase in retail trading activity corresponds with a 0.16 standard deviation increase in a stock's forward EV/sales multiple (roughly half a turn). Causality is difficult to prove through this analytical framework, however. Retail investors are generally more active in high valuation stocks (Exhibit 16), and the relationship between retail trading and valuation multiples may reflect a preference for stocks with valuations that are driven by a variable absent from our model.

Exhibit 21: Growth and profitability are stronger drivers of valuation than retail trading activity
Standardized coefficients based on results of cross-sectional regression. All variables significant at 1% level.

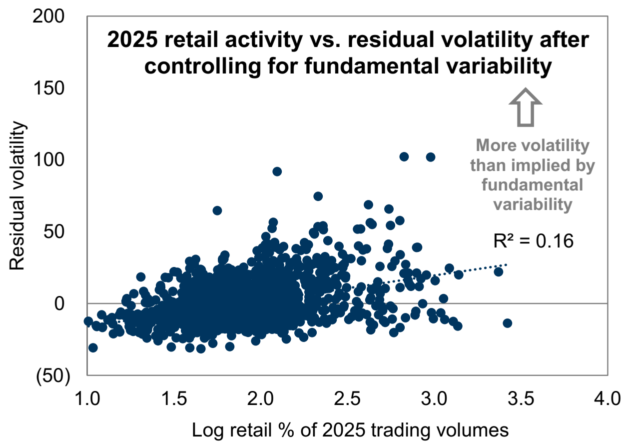


Regression based on universe of Russell 3000 stocks with market caps greater than $2 billion, excluding Biotech, Financials, Real Estate, and Utilities. Sales growth based on 1-year forward consensus estimates; profitability based on 1-year forward consensus estimates of EBITDA margins Retail activity based on retail share of trading volumes in 2021 and 2026 YTD; leverage is measured by Assets/Equity ratio.

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Similarly, higher retail activity in stocks has been associated with greater volatility, even after taking into account fundamental variability. One potential explanation for this relationship is that higher retail trading activity is a driver of stock volatility, although Exhibit 16 shows that retail traders are generally more active in volatile stocks. To control for fundamental sources of realized volatility, we include measures of a stock's historical variation in EBITDA growth, as well as earnings revisions.

Exhibit 22: Stocks with high volatility tend to have higher retail trading activity
Based on universe of Russell 3000 stocks



Residuals based on regression of stock 2025 volatility on consensus revisions to 2025 EPS estimates during 2025 and the standard deviation of 5-year trailing EBITDA growth.

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 23: Significant relationship between retail trading activity and stock volatility

Dependent variable: 2025 annualized stock volatility

Variable	Beta	T-stat
Log retail % of 2025 trading volumes	18.40	18.1**
Revision to 2025 EPS	0.03	2.5*
Log trailing 5-year EBITDA variability	4.01	14.5**
Observations	**1763**	
R^2	**0.28**	

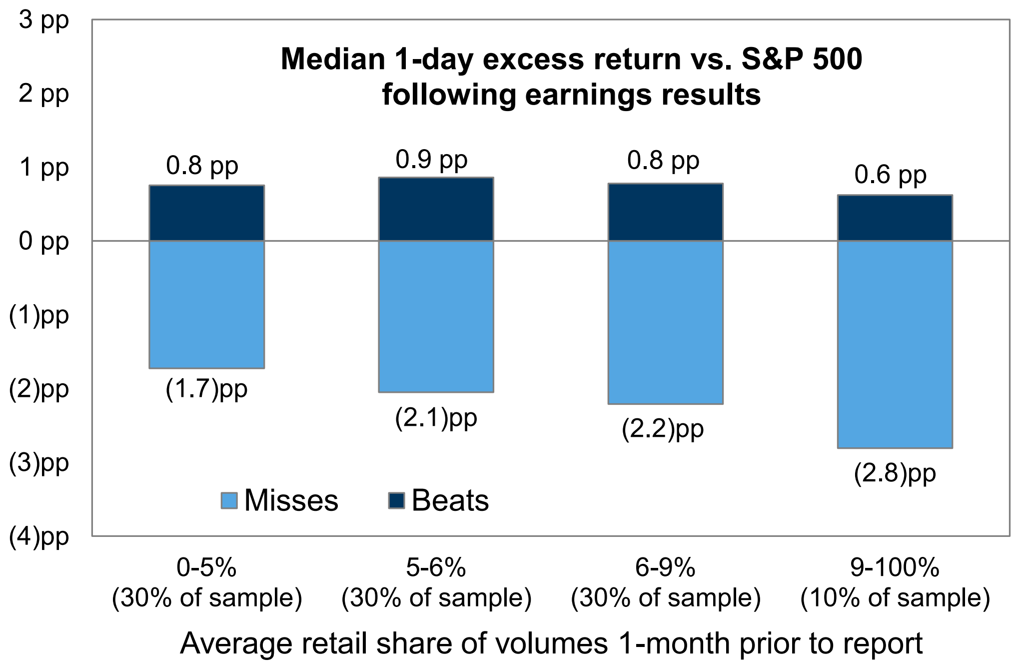
* and ** denote significance at 5% and 1% levels. Starting universe of Russell 3000 stocks, stocks without full data for all variables are excluded from sample.

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Stocks with high levels of retail trading activity have exhibited greater underperformance than stocks with lower levels of retail trading activity following negative earnings surprises. These results suggest that high levels of retail trading activity may impact how stocks react to new fundamental information. Our analysis captures the post-earnings performance of S&P 500 stocks across a sample of earnings surprises since 2021. Other research[3] has found retail trading activity can lead to higher stock volatility, valuations, and returns.

[3] See Eaton et al. (2022), Han and Kumar (2013), and Guo et al (2026).

Exhibit 24: Stocks with higher retail trading activity trade differently around earnings surprises
S&P 500 stocks' earnings results since 2021



Earnings beats and misses are defined as earnings results that are above or below consensus expectations by at least one standard deviation of estimates.

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Appendix

Exhibit 25: Top 25 constituents of GSXURFAV based on retail share of trading volumes YTD

Ticker	Name	Sector	Mkt cap ($ billion)	YTD return	12m return	Retail % of volumes YTD	2027 sales growth	NTM EV/ sales
AAL	American Airlines Group Inc.	Industrials	8	(17)%	13 %	27 %	4 %	0.6 x
NU	Nu Holdings Ltd.	Financials	73	(21)	11	21	21	4.1
SOFI	SoFi Technologies Inc	Financials	25	(39)	21	20	22	4.0
TSLA	Tesla, Inc.	Consumer Discretionary	1,473	(4)	28	18	15	13.9
APLD	Applied Digital Corporation	Information Technology	9	79	497	18	109	20.6
SNDK	Sandisk Corporation	Information Technology	135	512	3795	17	41	5.9
HIMS	Hims & Hers Health, Inc.	Health Care	7	(23)	(54)	17	20	2.0
INTC	Intel Corporation	Information Technology	330	227	502	16	11	10.6
PLTR	Palantir Technologies Inc.	Information Technology	349	(23)	10	16	44	38.6
MU	Micron Technology, Inc.	Information Technology	506	169	723	16	33	5.7
AMD	Advanced Micro Devices, Inc.	Information Technology	448	109	306	16	52	12.5
RKLB	Rocket Lab Corporation	Industrials	52	69	362	15	39	67.8
F	Ford Motor Company	Consumer Discretionary	51	(6)	21	15	(1)	0.9
NVDA	NVIDIA Corporation	Information Technology	4,910	18	68	15	34	13.3
HOOD	Robinhood Markets, Inc.	Financials	82	(31)	24	15	23	15.6
PFE	Pfizer Inc.	Health Care	157	7	19	14	(4)	3.3
ASTS	AST SpaceMobile, Inc.	Communication Services	24	0	203	13	344	57.2
SMCI	Super Micro Computer, Inc.	Information Technology	17	12	(18)	13	22	0.6
MSTR	Strategy Inc	Information Technology	59	21	(50)	13	2	152.0
COIN	Coinbase Global, Inc.	Financials	56	(8)	(21)	13	24	7.8
AAOI	Applied Optoelectronics, Inc.	Information Technology	12	440	953	12	169	8.4
APP	AppLovin Corp.	Information Technology	166	(27)	38	12	30	18.4
BE	Bloom Energy Corporation	Industrials	62	223	1341	12	70	19.6
WDC	Western Digital Corporation	Information Technology	127	184	878	11	31	11.1
ORCL	Oracle Corporation	Information Technology	511	(4)	21	11	41	7.7

Basket developed by GBM

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Goldman Sachs FICC and Equities

Exhibit 26: Estimation methodology of household ownership of equities

Household ownership category	Estimation methodology
ETFs	We start with the value of corporate equity assets held by ETFs from the Federal Reserve's latest Z.1 data release. Because ETFs can be held by other investor types besides households we estimate the share of ETFs' corporate equity assets held by households. We estimate this share by calculating the split between institutional (13F filers) and non-institutional ownership of the 100 largest US equity ETFs by AUM and assume the share of assets not held by institutions corresponds to households.
Retirement accounts	We utilize the value of corporate equity assets held by private and public pension funds from the Federal Reserve's latest Z.1 data.
Mutual funds	We start with the value of corporate equity assets held by Mutual Funds from the Federal Reserve's latest Z.1 data release. We estimate the share of these assets that are owned by households by dividing the value of mutual fund shares on household balance sheets by total mutual fund assets. Both of these figures are obtained from the Federal Reserve's Z.1 data release.
Direct ownership of individual equities	We start with the value of corporate equity assets held by Households from the Federal Reserve's latest Z.1 data. Because this figure includes the value of closed-end fund and ETF shares we subtract the value of closed-end funds' corporate equity holdings taken from the Z.1 release and subtract the value of household's equity ownership via ETFs utilizing our estimate described above.
Equity assets in self-directed brokerage accounts	We start with the value of retail self-directed assets based on data from Cerulli Associates and estimates from GS Research. We then assume that 70% of these assets are allocated to equities. This assumption is supported by data from ICI and EBRI which shows the average allocation of 401(k) plan assets to equities was 70% in 2022. We would expect self-directed brokerage accounts to exhibit a more risk-on asset allocation relative to 401(k) plan allocations so we view our estimate as conservative.

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Disclosure Appendix

Reg AC

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